



In 1837, artist Steuben depicted the Battle of Tours–Poitiers as a clash over the fate of Christian Europe. In reality Islamic raiders were beaten back in a minor skirmish.

1,050

PEOPLE PER SQUARE MILE THE POPULATION DENSITY OF TIKAL

SINCE CONQUERING SPAIN, ISLAMIC FORCES had made regular raids across the Pyrenees, striking deep into modern-day France before retreating to al-Andalus. In 721, an incursion into Aquitaine—a dukedom nominally in vassalage to the Frankish kingdom—had been checked by **Duke Eudo at the Battle of Toulouse**. But in 731, Eudo was unable to halt a fresh invasion of Islamic forces under **Abd al-Rahman I**, emir of al-Andalus. After defeat at the Battle of Arles, Eudo was forced to appeal to **Charles Martel**, the Frankish mayor of the palace, for help. Martel raised an army and met the Islamic forces on the banks of the Loire, between Tours and Poitiers, in 732. He was victorious at the **Battle of Tours–Poitiers**, and subsequent Christian historians would depict this as one of the defining clashes of the age—the moment at which Islamic expansion was

checked and Europe preserved for Christianity. Arabic sources record it as a minor skirmish, and in reality its main significance was that it demonstrated the need for the Frankish kingdoms to present a unified defense.

The **Maya city-states** of the Late Classic period reached the **peak of their power** and sophistication in the mid-8th century in Central America. The population of **Tikal**, for instance, swelled to at least 60,000, in a city spread out over 47 sq miles (76 sq km). Mayan rulers built stone temples, palaces, ballcourts, and observatories, and controlled a trade network stretching from California to South America. Yet the height of the city-states' glory sowed the **seeds of downfall**, as the populations

Statue of Chaak, Mayan god Mayans would have sought help from god of rain and thunder, Chaak, for their crops. Their civilization sat in a region of poor soil and fragile ecology, so rain was vital.



overtaxed the surrounding ecology and exceeded their ability to cope with drought. Collapse was just around the corner.



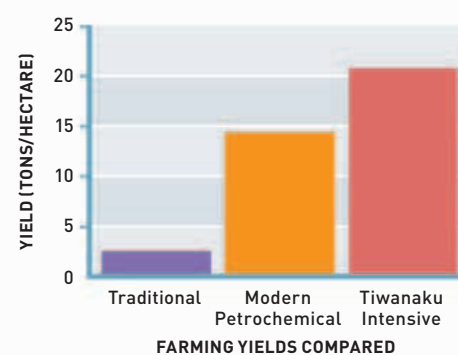
The Great Mosque at Samarra, Iraq, built by the Abbasid Caliphate. Once the largest mosque in the world, the minaret stands at 171 ft (52 m) tall.

THE FOUNDATION OF THE ABBASID CALIPHATE IN 750 was the culmination of growing tension in the Islamic world. Under the Umayyads (see 651–70) the Arab elite stubbornly maintained their special tax and political status, failing to deal with the growing grievances of the *mawali* (non-Arab Muslims). In 747, revolt broke out in Persian Khorasan, stronghold of the Abbasid clan, who traced their descent back to Muhammad through his uncle, al-Abbas. In 749, **Abu al-Abbas al-Saffah** was proclaimed caliph at Kufa in Iraq, and the following year at the **Battle of the Zab** he defeated Marwan II, the last Umayyad caliph. Marwan fled to Egypt but his head was sent back to Damascus, whereupon al-Saffah instigated a general massacre of the Umayyad clan to remove potential opposition.

In 741 **Charles Martel** (see 731–40) died and was succeeded by his sons **Pepin the Short** and

Carloman. In 748, Pepin had a son, Charles, who would go on to unite most of Western Europe under one banner (see 761–90).

Tiwanaku, a pre-Columbian city on the altiplano (high plains) of Bolivia, reached its height in around 750. Tiwanaku was the center of a civilization that flourished from the third to tenth centuries (see 951–60). The city itself was probably a **ceremonial and trading center**; its cultural and economic influence spread far through South America, and it would profoundly affect the development of later civilizations in the Andean region. Tiwanaku thrived in the harsh environment of the Bolivian altiplano thanks to its sophisticated **raised-field agriculture system** and extensive use of **terracing and irrigation**, which enabled it to achieve yields in excess of even modern petrochemical farming (see below), and supported the development of a sophisticated culture. The Tiwanaku people built pyramids, temples, and colossal statues.



Tiwanaku yields Raised fields and irrigation canals enabled Tiwanaku to achieve yields of up to 10 tons/acre [21 tons/hectare], according to experimental reconstructions.

- c. 731 English Monk Bede completes his History of the English People
- c. 730s Late Classic Maya civilization reaches height
- 732 Charles Martel defeats Arabic/Moorish forces at Battle of Tours–Poitiers
- 733 Trans-Saharan Arab expedition returns with quantities of gold
- 733 Tang state employs 17,680 civil servants
- 737 Charles Martel recaptures Avignon from Islamic forces
- 739 Kingdom of Asturias expands into Portugal
- 740 Battle of Acroinon: Leo III defeats Arabs in Anatolia
- c. 740 Chinese poetry evolving, with Li Po and Tu Fu active under Tang patronage
- 739 Charles Martel in alliance with Liutprand, King of the Lombards, drives Arabs from Provence

- 741 Death of Leo III, Byzantine Emperor
- 741 Death of Charles Martel, succeeded by Pepin the Short and Carloman
- 744 Assassination of Umayyad Caliph Walid II; Marwan II accedes to caliphate
- 745 Foundation of Uighur Empire in Central Asia
- 746 Terrible plague afflicts Byzantine empire
- 747 Pepin becomes sole ruler of Frankish kingdoms on his brother's death
- 749 Abu al-Abbas proclaimed caliph
- c. 750 Height of Maya city-state of Tikal in Central America, and pre-Inca Andean city-state of Tiwanaku
- 750 Battle of the Zab followed by general massacre of Umayyads